

# Chapter 1

## The Road to the Market

Nobody in the valley remembered a summer as dry as this one, and the river was low. At the corner of the market she stopped to listen to the old musician play his violin. He smiled at her as if he knew a secret that the rest of the world had forgotten.

The wind carried the smell of pine needles and wood smoke from the distant farms. She counted the coins in her pocket twice, just to be sure she had enough for the journey. Later that evening the clouds gathered in the west, heavy and dark with the promise of storms. Her brother laughed at her worries, but she noticed that he closed the shutters anyway.

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## **Chapter 2**

### **A Letter from the North**

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## **Chapter 3**

### **Storm over the Valley**

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